

SLICE OF LIFE Mohan Agashe with Siddharth Shaw in *Do Gubbare*

evolves from "where have I come to how can I leave this place".

Agashe himself never left Pune because he didn't want to give up his career as a psychiatrist, playing an instrumental role in setting up the Maharashtra Institute of Mental Health. Ward No. 26, the psychiatry ward at Pune Hospital, would go on to become Agashe's training ground for acting, enhancing his emotional quotient. "It was my means of survival. I have done many films without much money," he notes.

Combining psychiatry and acting for education and entertainment became Agashe's raison d'être. "This merging happened automatically because I found some cinema and theatre pieces were extremely handy in teaching about the mind," he says. "It is why I decided to continue with it." They included the works of Satyajit Ray, Shyam Benegal, and Sumitra Bhave and Sunil Sukthankar. It's in the works of the directing duo of Bhave and Sukthankar that Agashe found a means to "bridge the gap between bookish information and experiential wisdom". He produced and starred in their films, *Astu* (2015) and *Kaasav* (2016). "They teach us how to treat a person afflicted with disease and how to handle his or her family," says Agashe. "Like you choose a good book to read, you have to choose good cinema."

Agashe chose to stay in Pune even while pursuing a career in Hindi films in Bombay; today feelgood work is what keeps the veteran actor going

A lot of that is coming courtesy the younger filmmakers. Agashe featured in Bhartiya Digital Party's Harry Potter spoof and has done multiple short films in the last decade. "I was never offered such good roles as I have been in the last decade," he says. "The new generation is far more versed with the technique of filmmaking."

Feelgood work is what keeps the veteran actor going these days. His next, *Outhouse*, is a Hindi feature, which was also Bhave's last script before her demise. Also the film's producer, Agashe describes the plot as a friendship between a 73-year-old woman and a 75-year-old man played by Sharmila Tagore and Agashe, respectively. It also has a child and a puppy. "There's no violence, no villain, no suspense; it's a simple, straightforward story," he adds. The projects may not be a good return on investment but it's how the actor likes his cinema. Says Agashe, "I live very simply. I have never had to struggle—that's why I am not writing my autobiography." ■

Suhani Singh



YASIR IQBAL

THE KASHMIR FILES UNREPORTED CONSISTS OF RESEARCH, ARCHIVAL FOOTAGE AND INTERVIEWS THAT SHAPED THE FILM

propagandist nature.

In that sense, *The Kashmir Files Unreported* was conceived with the intention of disclosing the extent of the filmmaker's research—which includes testimonies of victims, journalists, cops and historians—in the "purest and rawest form" so that audiences, but mainly his critics, can understand that "the truth is difficult to handle". For Joshi, the chance to make *The Kashmir Files Unreported* offered a way for them to contextualise the four years of extensive research that led to *The Kashmir Files*, which went on to gross over Rs 300 crore at the box office last year. As a producer, Joshi, who also starred in *The Kashmir Files* alongside Anupam Kher, feels that it will be a series that every Indian should watch to fully realise the agony and pain of the Kashmiri Pandit community as well as what "Kashmir means to India". ■

Poulomi Das